



Great Mosque of Mecca

The largest mosque in the world, at Mecca in Saudi Arabia, and the focus of the annual hajj pilgrimage performed by Muslims from all parts of the globe



The site of the Great Mosque, also known as the Haram Mosque, was sacred ground long before the founding of Islam. Qur'anic tradition attributes the creation of the Kaaba—the granite cuboid structure around which the mosque is built—to the Biblical figure Abraham. It was a focal point of polytheistic worship for Arab tribes until 630 CE, when the Prophet Muhammad adopted it for the exclusive use of his monotheistic faith. The Kaaba became the holiest site in Islam, toward which all Muslims face when praying, and the object of the *hajj*—a pilgrimage that every Muslim is urged to make at least once in a lifetime. The mosque's courtyard houses not only the Kaaba but also the Station of Abraham—a stone bearing the imprint of Abraham's foot—and the sacred spring known as the Zamzam Well.

Expansion and modernization

The first mosque had been built around the Kaaba by the 8th century, but none of the original building remains. The oldest extant parts of the mosque's structure date from 1571, when it was rebuilt by the Ottoman Turkish architect Sinan. Most of the current building is far more recent, constructed in the 20th or 21st centuries. The need to cope with the ever larger number of pilgrims has led to massive expansion and modernization of the mosque since the 1950s. It now covers an area of some 4.3 million square ft (400,000 square m) and has escalators, pedestrian tunnels, and air conditioning. The mosque can now hold more than 800,000 pilgrims at a time. Admittance to the city of Mecca and its mosque is strictly forbidden to non-Muslims.



△ GOLD DOORS

The current gold entrance doors of the Kaaba were added in 1982. They are opened twice a year for the ceremonial "cleaning of the Kaaba."

Almost **3 million Muslims** make the pilgrimage to Mecca **every year**